

Module 12: Media, Narratives, and Representation

Graduate Research Project

Framing the Migrant: A Content Analysis of Media Coverage

Overview

A systematic content analysis of migration coverage across contrasting outlets, testing how framing varies and how it tracks policy moments.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Critique narrative construction systematically (Grad 1)
- Evaluate influence of narratives on policy (Grad 2)

Sample research questions

- How do frames (threat, victim, contributor, invasion, crisis) distribute across your chosen outlets and period?
- Whose voices are quoted — migrants, officials, advocates — and how does sourcing shape the frame?
- Do framing shifts precede, follow, or track policy events in your window?

Methods

Quantitative content analysis: defined sampling frame (outlets, dates, search terms), a documented codebook, double-coding a subsample for reliability, plus qualitative close reading of exemplar pieces.

IRB / research ethics

Not required — published media content.

Deliverables

- Codebook and corpus documentation (methods appendix)
- 4,500-word study with frequency tables/charts
- One-page 'reading the news about migration' guide for undergraduates

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Sampling and codebook rigor 30%	Method is rigorous and transparent: sampling and codebook rigor is fully documented, choices are justified, limitations are stated, and another student could replicate the work from what is written.	Method is sound: sampling and codebook rigor is documented and mostly justified, with limitations acknowledged; small gaps would not change the findings.	Method is partial: sampling and codebook rigor is described but under-documented or inconsistently applied, leaving findings plausible but not checkable.	Method is absent or unsound: sampling and codebook rigor is missing, undocumented, or applied so loosely that the findings cannot be trusted.
Coding reliability and transparency 25%	Method is rigorous and transparent: coding reliability and transparency is fully documented, choices are justified, limitations are stated, and another student could replicate the work from what is written.	Method is sound: coding reliability and transparency is documented and mostly justified, with limitations acknowledged; small gaps would not change the findings.	Method is partial: coding reliability and transparency is described but under-documented or inconsistently applied, leaving findings plausible but not checkable.	Method is absent or unsound: coding reliability and transparency is missing, undocumented, or applied so loosely that the findings cannot be trusted.
Quality of the framing-to-policy analysis 30%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: quality of the framing-to-policy analysis goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: quality of the framing-to-policy analysis is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: quality of the framing-to-policy analysis is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: quality of the framing-to-policy analysis is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Accessibility of the student guide 15%	Communication is publication-ready: accessibility of the student guide is achieved with precise, well-organized prose, correct citation, and figures or formats that make the argument easier to grasp.	Communication is clear and professional: accessibility of the student guide is achieved with minor lapses in polish, organization, or citation that never obscure meaning.	Communication is understandable but rough: accessibility of the student guide is only partly achieved — disorganization, citation errors, or unclear figures make the reader work to follow the argument.	Communication impedes the work: accessibility of the student guide is not achieved; errors, disorganization, or missing citations obscure the substance.